ENTERTAINMENT

INDIAN AT HEART

Behind the success of ***Spider-Man: Across the Spider-Verse*** are the many Indian animators who worked on the project

"Chai tea? Chai means 'tea', bro! You are saying 'tea tea'! Would I ask you for a 'coffee coffee' with room for 'cream cream'?" It's one of the lines in the animated film *Spider-Man: Across the Spider-Verse* that leaves audiences in Indian cinemas in splits. Its deliverer is Pavitr Prabhakar, a desi Spider-Man based in the crowded, bustling city of Mumbattan, with luscious hair that he credits to coconut oil and genes. He feeds stray dogs, loves his girlfriend Gayatri and displays a robust joie de vivre in the 12-odd minutes of his screentime. Voiced by cricketer Shubman Gill in the Hindi-dubbed version, the film saw the biggest weekend for an animated movie in India.

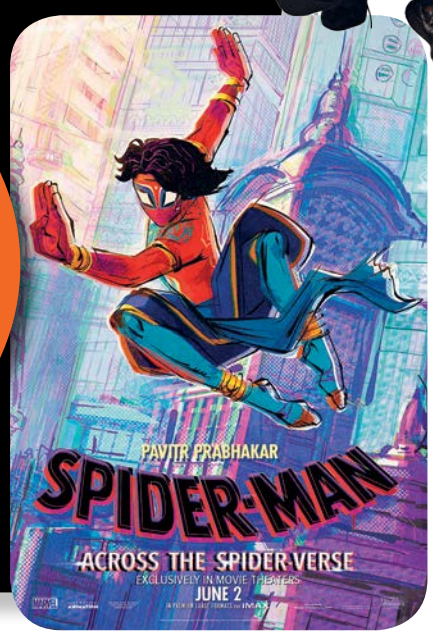
Of the 1,000-odd animators who worked on the film, at least a few were Indians. Some of them took to social media to identify their inspirations. Visual development artist Naveen Selvanathan noted how theatre forms like Kerala's Theyyam and Koothu and Karnataka's Yakshagana were referred to while designing Prabhakar's face. Harinarayan Rajeev, senior animator on the project, recognised the efforts of his colleagues, including lead animator Nick Kondo, who turned to Kalaripayattu for the moves Prabhakar would strike.

Others like visual consultant Aymeric Kevin cited Indrajal Comics from the 1960s as a reference for developing Mumbattan. Chelsea Gordon-Ratzlaff, who worked on rendering Pavitr's entry scene and his backstory, was told to watch the film *RRR* for the "crazier slow motion stuff", as he recalls on his Tumblr account. Rohini Kumar, another supervising animator, suggested the word 'tadak' as a substitute for terms like 'wham!' or 'pow' seen in comics, when Pavitr uses his bracelets to unleash the webs.

The effusive response to Pavitr Prabhakar has buoyed the likes of Rajeev. He took to Twitter to share a photo of the posse of Kerala animators and engineers who worked on the film. In an interview to INDIA TODAY, he listed their roles: Nideep Varghese and Sinu Raghavan were senior animators; Kurian Onnunny Samuel contributed as a senior software engineer, and Binku Mathews and Joseph Tom Neriamparampil served as senior software pipeline tool designers.

Currently a senior animator at WetaFX in Vancouver, Rajeev has another film running in cinemas—*Transformers: Rise of the Beasts*. For him, what made *Spider-Verse* stand out was "the different frame rates at which each of the characters are animated". "Animators required knowledge of body mechanics, technical expertise and a good sense of art and appeal," he adds. "Each pose is crafted with the same precision as a comic book artist, to ensure the final output resembles an illustration." ■

Suhani Singh



MUSIC

Spinning a Musical Web

Tech Panda x Kenzani have reimagined Post Malone and Swae Lee's 2018 smash hit 'Sunflower' in a distinctly Indian avatar for the latest Spiderman movie

About halfway through the latest Spiderman movie *Across the Spider-Verse*, as the film's superhero protagonists traverse multiverse timelines to land up in Mumbattan—a futuristic hybrid of Manhattan and Mumbai—you can hear a sitar, santoor and flute floating in tentative counterpoint, teasing a familiar refrain. Those are the opening strains of a velveteen Hindi-folk-electronica reworking of Post Malone and Swae Lee's 2018 smash hit 'Sunflower', a standout track from the friendly neighbourhood web-slinger's previous outing, *Spiderman: Into the Spider-Verse*.

New Delhi producer duo Tech Panda x Kenzani—Rupinder Nanda and Kedar Santwani—were roped in by Sony Music to reimagine the dreamy ballad in their signature emotive fusion-focused electronica style. The two have had some big wins in their five years working together, like the bouncy club hit 'Dilbar', an innovative collaboration with experimental producers Rusha & Blizza that has racked up millions of streams in six months. But this was an opportunity to showcase their work on a much bigger stage.



"We were asked to revisit the track in the signature Tech Panda & Kenzani sound, which is really an amalgamation of the traditional Indian sound with clean electronica soundscapes," the duo said. "We wanted the track to display a clear blend of Indian instruments and sounds, and maintain the soul of the original yet create a new space for itself."

It's fair to say that Tech Panda and Kenzani—and vocalist Badal—hit the target with their Hindi reprise of 'Sunflower'. The duo, who have released over 80 tracks together over the past five years, are also gearing up for the release of their latest single 'Kulli'. As a final aside, Indian independent music fans will also have recognised a snippet of Nucleya's 'Bakar Bakar 'from the 2016 *Raja Baja* album playing during a Mumbattan scene in *Across the Spider-Verse*. File that under more evidence of Indian sounds finding their way to global audiences. ■

Bhanuj Kappal